stride, and not making the decision whether to bowl around or over the wicket until the last possible moment.

Shock and awe. KP was made for the IPL and he knew it.

I marvel at such skill and audacity. I played my first scoop against Chris Jordan, having never practised it in my life. I was 80-odd not out, calculated he was going to bowl a yorker and used beginner's luck to paddle it. Bowlers learn quickly, however. The slower ball, out of the back of the hand, is old hat these days. It's now delivered even slower, from deeper in the hand.

Batsmen have to cope with slower-ball bouncers, knuckle balls adapted from baseball. Some of the balls wobble like freshly set jelly. They are no longer inclined to submit to the yorker and are primed to create or make the most of fractional errors in length. Bowlers are trying to get their retaliation in first, before they are brutalized by batsmen like Buttler, who hit eleven consecutive boundaries against the West Indies in February 2019 and needed only thirty-two deliveries to go from 50 to 150.

Glorious, but ridiculous. I dare you not to love it.

Watching Buttler or Chris Gayle in full flow is like playing *Brian Lara Cricket* on the PC when we were kids. They are the Superman Cheat, which lets you hit every ball for four or six, in human form. I was in the Essex dressing room, watching TV, when England just missed out on 500 at Trent Bridge, and someone said, 'They're playing a game which is just not real …'

It looked so easy. I was in awe of what those guys were doing, even though I had played alongside them in different forms of the game. I haven't got their type of talent, their free-form creativity, our equivalent of a cross between jazz and heavy metal. Could they bat for eleven hours in 40-degree heat on a ground so silent you can hear nesting birds in the roof of the stand? Possibly not, though Ben Stokes wouldn't need to hang around that long, in any case, to brush up on his ornithology.

It's different strokes for different folks in its most literal sense, but there are unifying factors. Jos Buttler is the poster boy for this new form of cricket, but Shane Warne, his mentor in the IPL with Rajasthan Royals, gave him the confidence to transfer his skills into the Test arena. It took time for him to come to terms with red-ball cricket, but he admits: 'I'm desperate to reach my potential.' His versatility is deeply impressive, made to measure. He opens with violent intent in T20. In the fifty-over game he's